

Design Challenge App – 10 Core Challenges

Each challenge has 3 steps: the original prompt + 2 follow-ups.

Each step includes a context note and 1–2 embedded design principles.

01 · E-Commerce · The Product Card

Step 1 Design a product card for a sustainable fashion brand. Focus on hierarchy: what does the user need to see first, second, third?

🎓 *Apply Gestalt's Law of Proximity — group related elements (price, name, rating) so the eye reads them as a unit, not as isolated pieces.*

Step 2 Design a product detail page that this card leads to. The user has clicked because they're interested — now earn their trust and guide them toward a decision.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #6: Recognition over Recall — make size guides, return policies, and material info visible without the user having to dig for it.*

Step 3 Design the shopping cart screen after the user adds the item. This is a moment of commitment — make it feel reassuring, not anxiety-inducing.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #1: Visibility of System Status — clearly confirm what was added, show the updated total, and make the path to checkout obvious.*

02 · Wellness · The Meditation Timer

Step 1 Design a meditation timer screen for a mindfulness app. The interface should feel as calm as the activity itself — strip away everything unnecessary.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Visual Breathing — generous white space isn't emptiness, it's intentional calm. Let the layout reflect the purpose.*

Step 2 Design the session completion screen shown after the timer ends. This is a small but meaningful moment — the user just did something good for themselves.

🎓 *Apply the Peak-End Rule — users remember the best moment and the ending. Make this ending feel rewarding and warm, not clinical.*

Step 3 Design the session history screen where users can see their past practice. Progress should feel encouraging, not like a report card.

🎓 *Apply Gestalt's Law of Continuity — use visual flow (a timeline, a gentle graph) to suggest ongoing progress rather than isolated data points.*

03 · Productivity · The Task Card

Step 1 Design a task card for a project management tool used by small creative teams. One card, all the essential info — make it scannable in under 3 seconds.

🎓 *Apply the Inverted Pyramid principle — lead with the most critical information (task name, status, deadline) and let secondary details follow.*

Step 2 Design the task detail screen that opens when the card is tapped. The user needs full context to act — give them everything without overwhelming them.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #8: Aesthetic and Minimalist Design — every element on this screen should earn its place. If it doesn't help the user act, remove it.*

Step 3 Design the project overview screen that contains multiple task cards. This is the bird's eye view — help the user understand the health of the whole project at a glance.

🎓 *Apply Gestalt's Law of Similarity — use consistent visual treatment (color, shape, size) to group tasks by status so patterns emerge instantly.*

04 · Food & Lifestyle · The Recipe Card

Step 1 Design a recipe card for a meal planning app targeting busy parents. Quick to scan, easy to decide — yes or no in seconds.

🎓 *Apply the F-Pattern Reading principle — place the most decision-influencing content (image, time, difficulty) along the natural scan path.*

Step 2 Design the full recipe screen once the user selects a meal. They're about to cook — anticipate what they'll need and when they'll need it.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #7: Flexibility and Efficiency — consider both the first-time cook (needs full instructions) and the experienced one (just needs a quick ingredient check).*

Step 3 Design the weekly meal planner screen where this recipe has been added. Help the user see their whole week without feeling overwhelmed by it.

🎓 *Apply Gestalt's Law of Prägnanz (Good Form) — the brain prefers simplicity. Design the week view so it reads as one coherent, organized whole rather than 7 separate days.*

05 · Finance · The Expense Entry

Step 1 Design an expense entry screen for a personal budgeting app. Adding an expense should take no more than 10 seconds — remove every unnecessary tap.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #4: Consistency and Standards — use familiar input patterns (amount first, then category) so users don't have to relearn the flow each time.*

Step 2 Design the category selection screen or component triggered during entry. Categories should be immediately recognizable — no guessing where "coffee" belongs.

🎓 *Apply Gestalt's Law of Common Region — visually enclose related categories (Food & Drink, Transport, Health) so groupings feel intuitive rather than arbitrary.*

Step 3 Design the monthly spending overview screen. The user wants to understand their habits — show them patterns, not just numbers.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Data-Ink Ratio (Edward Tufte) — every visual element should represent data. Remove decorative chart elements that add noise without adding meaning.*

06 · Travel · The Destination Card

Step 1 Design a destination card for a travel inspiration app. Spark wanderlust in a single card — make the user feel something before they read anything.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Visual Hierarchy through contrast — a strong image paired with minimal, well-placed type creates more impact than a card crowded with information.*

Step 2 Design the destination detail screen this card leads to. The user is dreaming — help them go from inspiration to "I want to book this."

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #6: Recognition over Recall — surface key facts (best season, average cost, visa requirements) without making the user search for them.*

Step 3 Design the trip planning screen where the user starts building their itinerary. The blank slate is intimidating — give them a starting point that feels manageable.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Progressive Disclosure — show only what's needed to take the first step. Reveal complexity gradually as the user builds confidence.*

07 • Health • The Symptom Checker

Step 1 Design a symptom input screen for a healthcare app. Users arrive here worried — the interface must feel calm, clear, and trustworthy.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #5: Error Prevention — use clear input options (selectable symptoms rather than free text) to reduce user error and anxiety simultaneously.*

Step 2 Design the results screen showing possible conditions based on entered symptoms. This is sensitive information — present it honestly without causing unnecessary panic.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Tone through Typography — font weight, size, and spacing can make the same information feel alarming or reassuring. Choose deliberately.*

Step 3 Design the "find a doctor" screen that follows the results. The user needs to act — make the path from concern to appointment as frictionless as possible.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #3: User Control and Freedom — give users options (book now, save for later, get more info) so they feel in control of a moment that may feel out of control.*

08 · Social · The User Profile

Step 1 Design a user profile card for a design community platform. In one glance, a visitor should understand who this person is and whether to connect.

🎓 *Apply Gestalt's Law of Figure/Ground — make the profile subject (photo, name, role) stand out clearly from the background and supporting details.*

Step 2 Design the full profile page this card expands into. The user is being evaluated by potential collaborators or employers — help them tell their story.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Visual Narrative — guide the viewer's eye through a deliberate sequence: who they are → what they do → proof of their work → how to connect.*

Step 3 Design the connection or collaboration request screen triggered from the profile. A small but high-stakes interaction — make it personal, not transactional.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #2: Match Between System and the Real World — use language and metaphors that feel human ("Let's connect") rather than technical ("Send request").*

09 · Education · The Course Card

Step 1 Design a course card for an online learning platform targeting adult learners. Adults are time-conscious and skeptical — give them what they need to decide in seconds.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Affordance — visual cues (progress bar, duration badge, level indicator) should immediately communicate what kind of commitment this course requires.*

Step 2 Design the course overview screen the card leads to. The user is considering enrolling — address their hesitations before they voice them.

🎓 *Apply Nielsen's Heuristic #6: Recognition over Recall — make the syllabus, instructor credentials, and time commitment visible upfront. Don't make users hunt for deal-breakers.*

Step 3 Design the first lesson screen once the user enrolls. First impressions set the tone for the entire learning journey — make this feel welcoming and structured.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Onboarding through Context — orient the learner: where are they in the course, what will they achieve today, and what comes next.*

10 · Utility · The Onboarding Flow

Step 1 Design the first onboarding screen for a habit-building app. You have one screen to convince someone to keep going — make every word and pixel count.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Value-First Onboarding — lead with what the user gains, not what you need from them (permissions, sign-ups, personal data).*

Step 2 Design the personalization step mid-onboarding where the user sets their first goal. This is the moment of investment — the user is telling you what they care about.

🎓 *Apply the principle of Commitment and Consistency (Cialdini) — small, voluntary choices early in an onboarding flow increase the likelihood of long-term engagement.*

Step 3 Design the "you're all set" completion screen at the end of onboarding. The user has made it through — celebrate that without being over the top.

🎓 *Apply the Peak-End Rule again — this is the end of the onboarding experience. Make it feel like a beginning, not a finish line.*

Total: 10 challenges × 3 steps = 30 individual design prompts Educational principles covered: Gestalt Laws, Nielsen's Heuristics, Typography principles, Cognitive psychology (Peak-End Rule, Cialdini), Data visualization (Tufte), Progressive Disclosure, Onboarding theory